A Model of Christian Charity

John Winthrop · 1630 (aboard the Arbella)

Source: John Winthrop, "A Model of Christian Charity," 1630

John Winthrop, first governor of the Massachusetts Bay Colony, delivered this lay sermon to fellow Puritans crossing the Atlantic. He described their colony as a covenant with God and a model for the world — the famous "city upon a hill." The sermon captures the religious mission, communal ideals, and sense of exceptional purpose that shaped New England society, in sharp contrast to the profit-driven Chesapeake.

Connect: How did the Puritans' religious purpose differ from the economic motives driving the founding of the Chesapeake colonies?

Key Passages

A city upon a hill

"For we must consider that we shall be as a city upon a hill. The eyes of all people are upon us; so that if we shall deal falsely with our God in this work we have undertaken … we shall be made a story and a by-word through the world."

Knit together as one

"We must be knit together in this work as one man. We must entertain each other in brotherly affection … we must delight in each other, make others' conditions our own, rejoice together, mourn together, labor and suffer together."

A covenant with God

"We are entered into covenant with Him for this work … if the Lord shall please to hear us, and bring us in peace to the place we desire, then hath He ratified this covenant."

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The Great Migration of Puritans to New England (1630s): Puritans who wanted to purify the Church of England left for Massachusetts Bay to build a godly community.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Fellow Puritan colonists on board the Arbella and the fleet sailing to Massachusetts Bay.
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	John Winthrop, a lawyer, devout Puritan, and the colony's first governor, who saw the colony as a covenant with God and wanted to keep its members united and obedient.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ practice (A·C·E): Explain ONE way Puritan beliefs shaped the development of New England society.

2. What does the phrase “city upon a hill” reveal about the Puritans’ sense of purpose?

3. How might this vision create tension for dissenters such as Roger Williams or Anne Hutchinson?